Basic Concepts in Feminism, and Gender and Politics

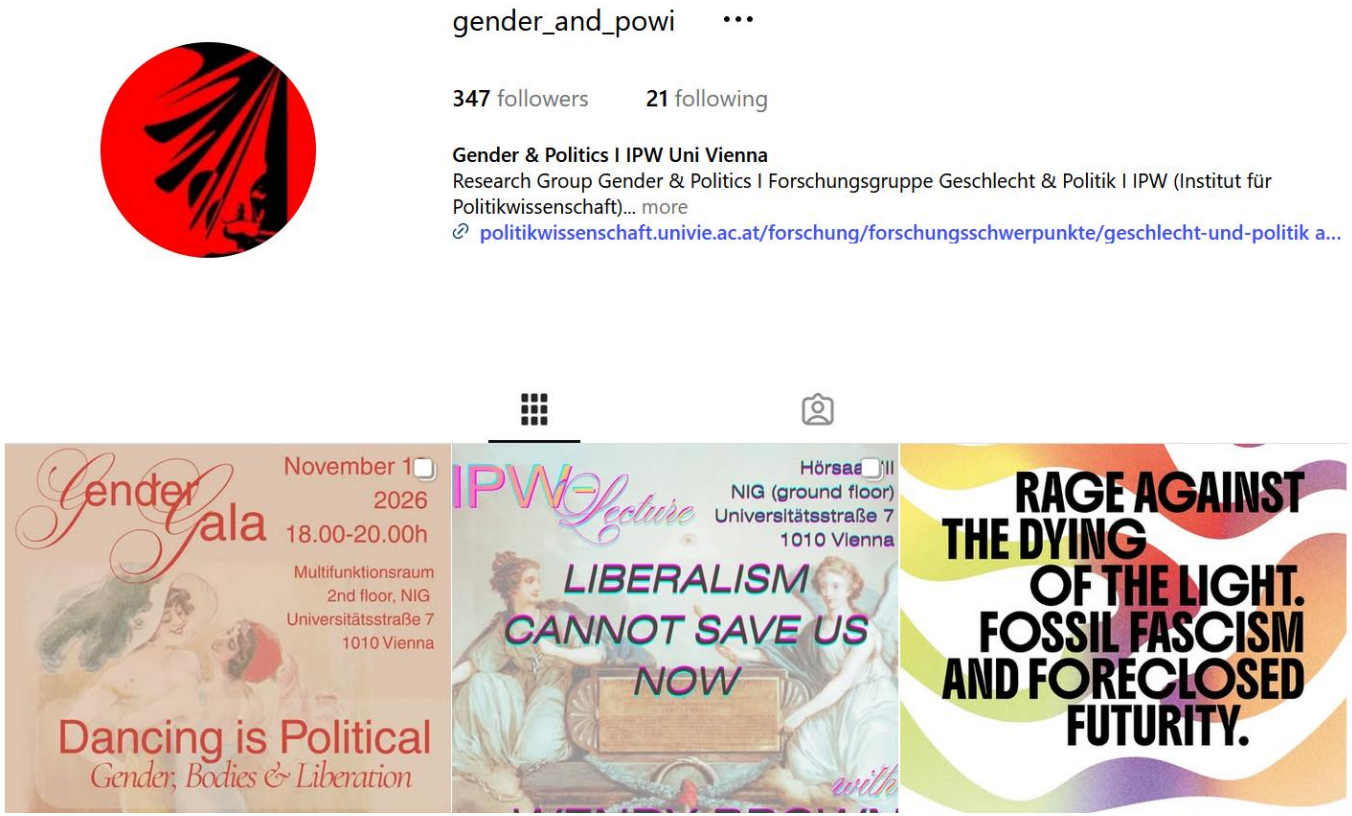
By: Univ.-Prof. Dr. Dorit Geva
Professor of Politics and Gender, IPW

About me and the “politics and gender” research group at the IPW:

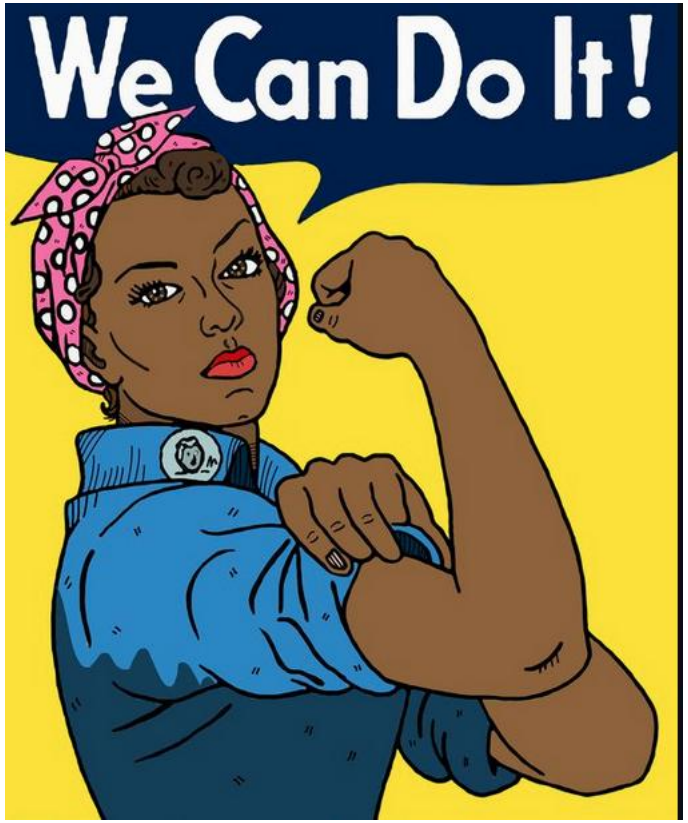
- Professor of Politics and Gender, Department of Political Science, University of Vienna
- PhD, New York University; previously at the European University Institute, the University of Chicago, and Professor and Dean at Central European University
- **My research:** gender and the far right in Europe; gender and military conscription (book with Cambridge University Press)
- For more on the “politics and gender” research group see:

https://politikwissenschaft.univie.ac.at/forschung/geschlecht-und-politik

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What is Feminism?



There’s no one definition, because there are many feminisms

A simple starting point:

Movements and ideas that seek equality between women and men

- **BUT:** feminists disagree about what “equality” means, and how to get there
- Each strand of feminism starts from different building blocks, so each one sees different problems and different solutions

Today: four feminist lenses

Each lens asks: **What is the problem?** and **What would change look like?**

1 Liberal feminism
Equal rights for individuals

2 Marxist feminism
Women, work and class

3 Intersectionality
Which women?

4 Gender as a construct
What is a "woman" anyway?

Our test case: gender quotas in parliament

There are many more feminisms. These four show the range of ideas and the tensions between them.

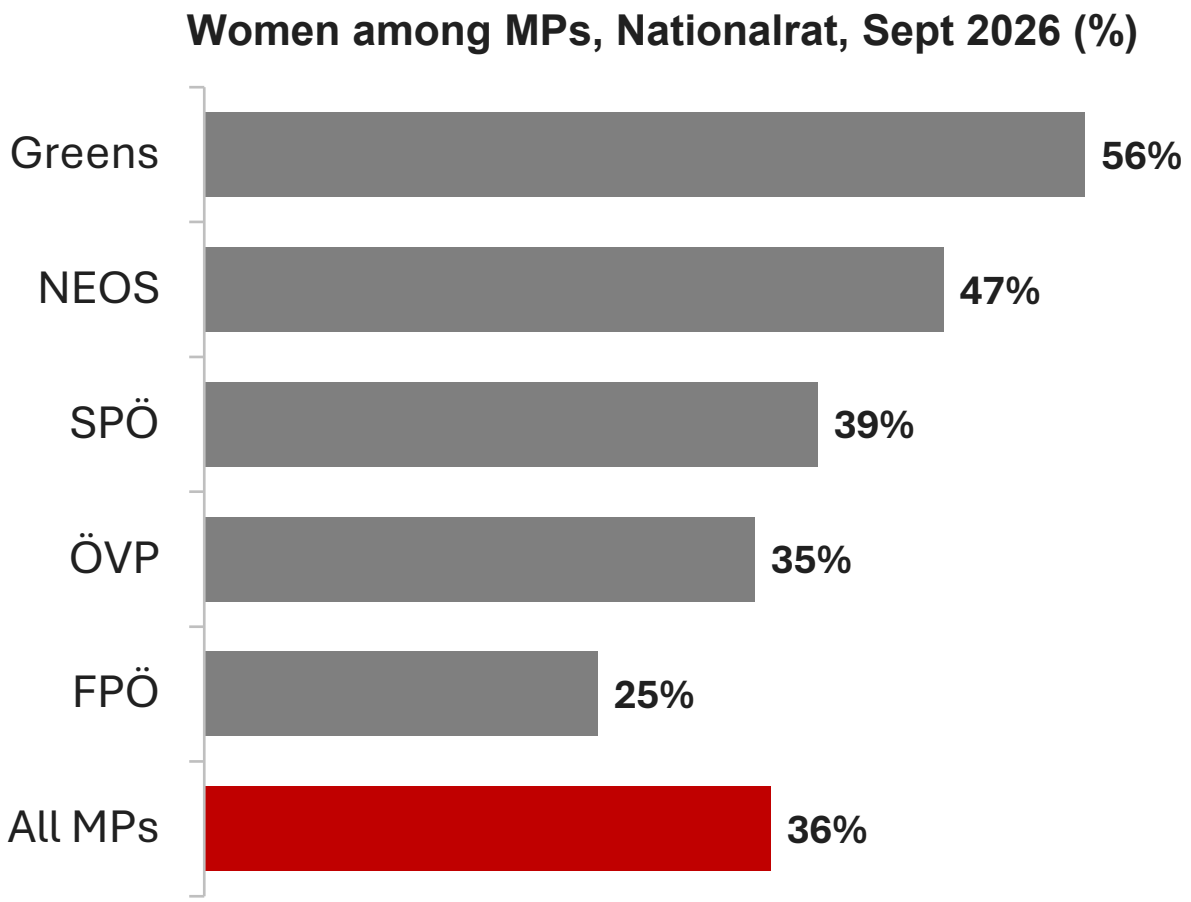
Our test case: quotas in parliament



- A gender quota sets a **minimum share of women** (often 40–50%) among a party's candidates
- **Legal quotas** apply to every party, e.g. France's parity law (2000): parties must run equal numbers of women and men
- **Voluntary quotas** are a party's own rule
- Austria has **no legal quota** for parliament; some parties set their own

Austria: who sits in parliament?





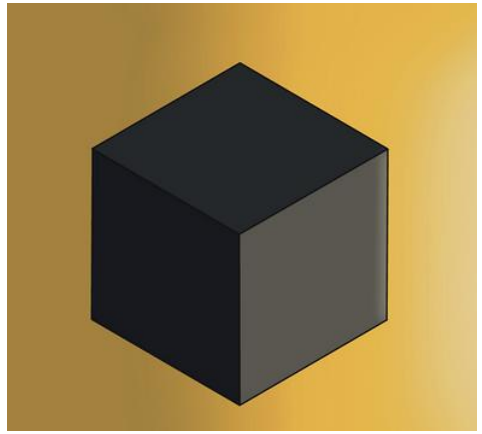
36%

of MPs are women: 65 of 183

From 25% to 56%: big differences between parties

Source: Austrian Parliament, personnel statistics, as of 23 Sept 2026

I. Liberal feminism's origin is in liberal political philosophy:



Liberalism is a political philosophy which, broadly:

Centers on **the primacy of the individual's autonomy, rights, and reason.**

Individuals as 'abstract' and equal – regardless of specific features. Like equal '**black boxes**'

From that as its basic premise, it considers how to create forms of government which protect individual rights, balancing fairness, and equality between individuals

I. Liberal Feminism

Men and women have the same individual rights [same black boxes]

- Fought for women's right to vote (suffrage)
- Women's right to run for elections and be in government
- Women's right to own property
- Women's right to divorce
- Women's equality in the marriage contract
- Today: women's right to equal pay



Liberal feminism's approach to change:

- Has focused extensively on **legal changes**. For example, right to vote. Marriage laws. Equal pay laws. Women's right to education. Reproductive rights (e.g. abortion).

- Mainly working for equality **within existing structures**.

- Approach has tended to be towards **gradual change**, within liberal democracy, within laws, and not towards radical systemic change.

Liberal feminism on parliamentary quotas: split positions



Liberal feminists agree on the goal (equal chances), but disagree about the tool

YES to quotas

Women are equal individuals, but party networks and gatekeepers block them

A quota removes an unfair barrier, so every individual gets a fair chance

NO to quotas

Remember the “black boxes”: liberalism treats people as individuals, not as members of a group

“Choose the best person”: a quota can look like it overrides merit

What both sides share: the **individual** and **equal rights** are the starting point. Neither questions the system itself.

II. Marxist Feminism

- Comes from the **generation of 1968**: student movements rediscovered Marxism, outside Soviet orthodoxy
- New feminist theories and movements grew out of this
- Goal: **systemic change**, not just change within existing laws and institutions

Marxist feminism: two systems of exploitation reinforce each other



- Starting point: **labour** (who works, who gets paid, who profits)
- Women face **two systems**: capitalism *and* patriarchy
- Patriarchy is older than capitalism, so ending capitalism alone would not end it
- Women are **doubly exploited**:
  - in paid work: often paid less (in Austria, women earn 17.6% less per hour, 2024)
  - in **unpaid** work at home: cooking, cleaning, caring, and raising the next generation of workers



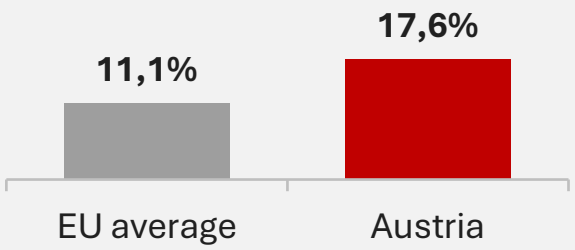
Austria comparatively lags behind Europe

Gender pay gap

per hour, 2024

Austria **17.6%**

EU average: 11.1%



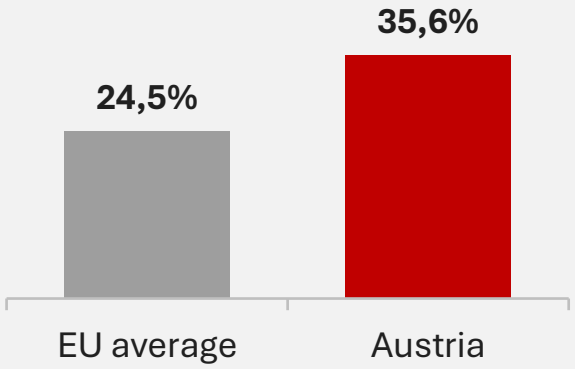
3rd-highest of 27 EU countries

Gender pension gap

people aged 65+, 2024

Austria **35.6%**

EU average: 24.5%



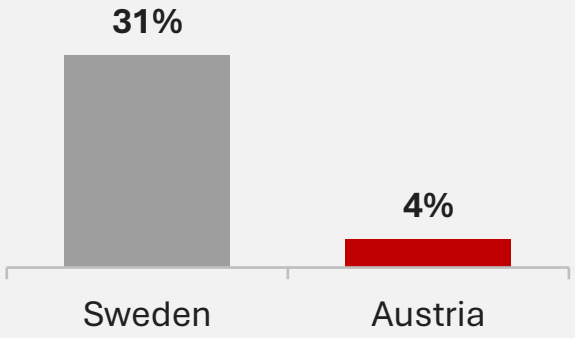
3rd-highest of 27 EU countries

Paternity leave

share of paid benefit days, 2022

Austria **4%**

Sweden: 31%



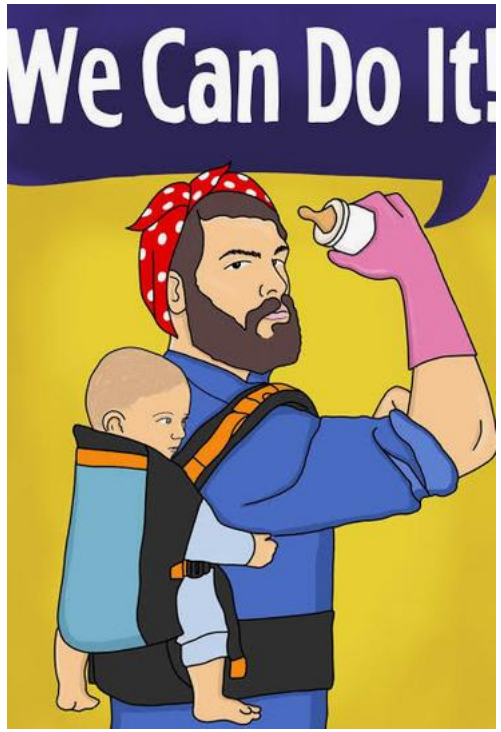
Norway and Iceland: 32%

Sources: Eurostat (pay gap 2024, provisional; pension gap 2024); Austrian Court of Audit (fathers' share of childcare-benefit days, 2022); OECD Family Database (Sweden, Norway, Iceland). All bars on the same 0–42% scale. Note also: these gaps are linked, especially the cumulative impact at old age (pensions)

What would change look like?



- **Most radical version:** end capitalism *and* patriarchy, since neither alone is enough
- **More practical version:**
  - **M**ake unpaid work visible as real work, e.g. the 1970s "Wages for Housework" campaign (picture)
  - **Equalize support of care work by the state**: redistribute the share of care work, e.g. offer paternity leave, not only maternity leave to raise children



- **Big contribution:** shifted feminism from formal liberal rights to material conditions: fairness in money, work, time
- **A critique:** it has tended to centre white, Western women. Intersectional feminists push back (our next lens)

Back to Parliaments:
Marxists on quotas: good, but not enough



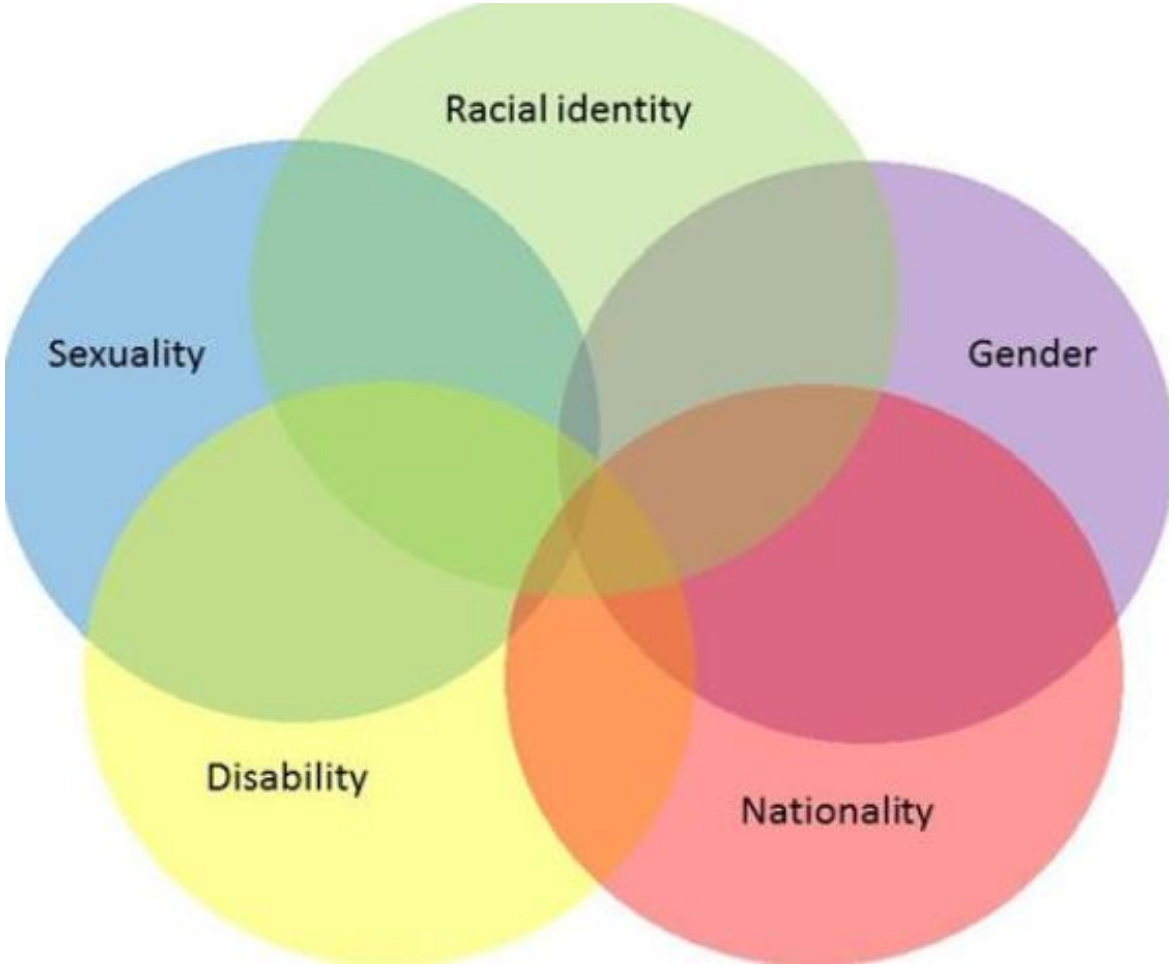
- More women in parliament: yes. But **which** women? Mostly lawyers, academics, party officials; rarely cashiers, cleaners or care workers
- The quota changes gender, but **class stays the same**
- A woman MP still votes with her party, and may vote *against* working women's interests (e.g. cutting childcare)
- Real change also needs changes to **work, wages and care**

Question: Which parliament would change more for ordinary women: one that is 50% women, or one where half the MPs used to be cashiers, nurses and construction workers?

III. Intersectionality and Women-of-Colour Feminism

- **Intersectionality**: a way to see how several structures (gender, race, class, sexuality, disability, religion, migration, age) work *together*
- They act at the same time, and can **bring advantages and disadvantages** at once
- Not a checklist of personal identities, but a **structural lens**: how institutions hand out resources, risks and recognition
- Term coined by US legal scholar **Kimberlé Crenshaw** (1989), building on Black feminist thinkers such as **bell hooks** and the **Combahee River Collective** (1977)

Not just overlapping identities: overlapping structures



Careful: a diagram like this can look like an identity checklist. The point is how **structures** shape positions.

An intersectional critique of (white) feminism

Intersectionality is also a critique of *white* feminism: feminism has long spoken for, and as if all women were, white women

> *"The value of feminist theory to Black women is diminished because it evolves from a white racial context that is seldom acknowledged. Not only are women of color in fact overlooked, but their exclusion is reinforced when **white** women speak for and as **women**."*
>
> Kimberlé Crenshaw (1989), "Demarginalizing the Intersection of Race and Sex"

What is Crenshaw saying?

- Mainstream (white) feminism claims to be **universal**: it speaks for all women
- But this “universal” voice comes from a white, middle-class position
- So white feminism reproduces the exclusion it criticizes in patriarchy: it swaps the white male universal subject for a white female one
- Women of colour are not just left out: their knowledge and experience are made invisible

See the **assigned reading by Christoffersen & Emejulu (2023)**

Christoffersen & Emejulu (2023): the critique continues

- More than 30 years after Crenshaw coined the term intersectionality, the struggle for intersectionality *within* feminism continues
- They studied feminist organizations in England and Scotland
- Finding: “intersectionality” is used as **nice-sounding language**, but practices have not really changed
- It becomes bureaucratic: about image, **not about who really makes decisions**
- “Diversity” becomes a buzzword, often an empty one

Christoffersen & Emejulu: what intersectional feminism should be

Centre those most marginalized (e.g. people of colour, disabled, trans and migrant women) as ***knowledge producers and leaders***

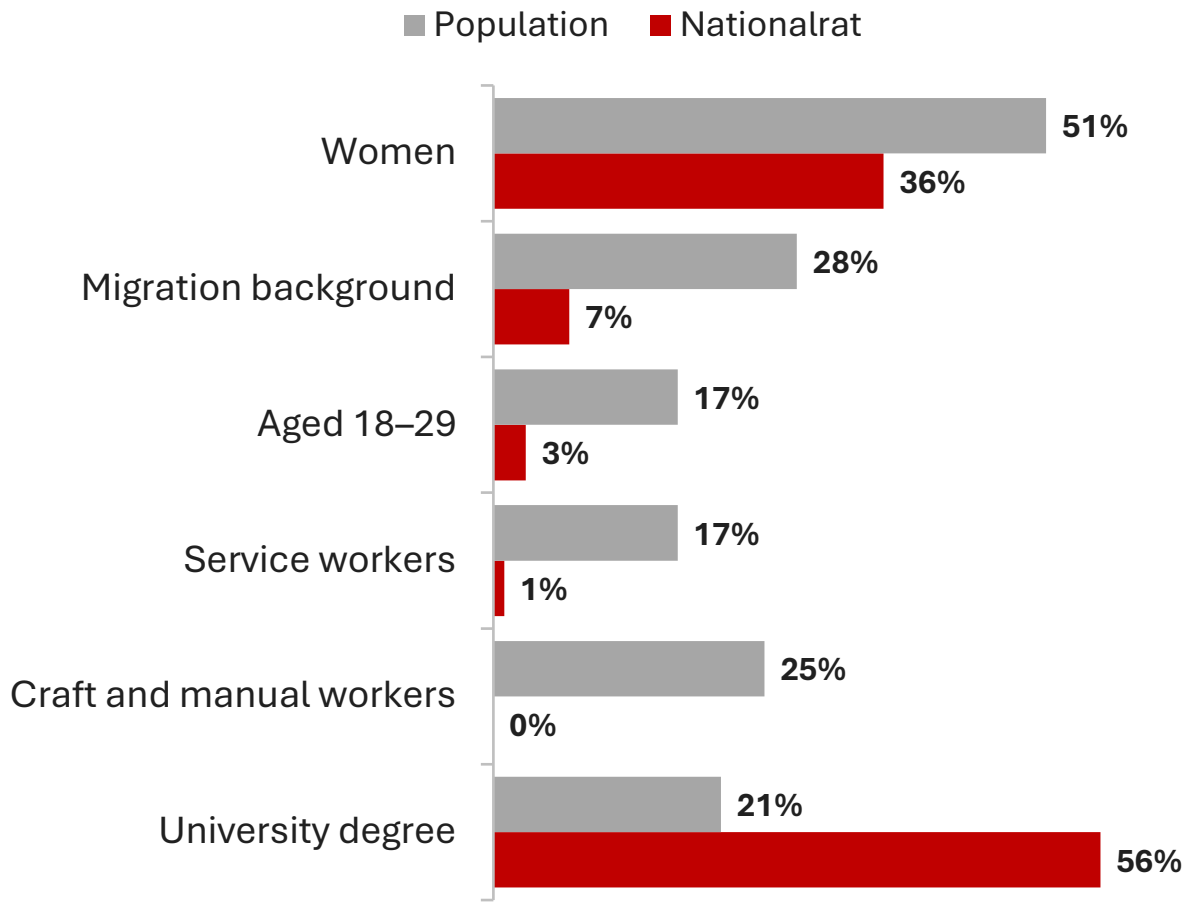
Takeaway: intersectionality isn't "adding more women" or token diversity. It's about **changing who gets to define what counts as feminism, who can produce knowledge, who is given capacity to make decisions and lead**

Intersectionality on quotas: which men and women get the seats?



- A gender quota counts “women” and “men” as **one group**, but women and men are not one group
- If the new seats go mostly to white, native-born, university-educated women, has parliament become equal?
- A global study of 81 countries (Hughes 2011): quotas rarely challenge **majority men’s** dominance; minority women gain most when quotas address gender *and* ethnicity together
- The question is not just *how many* women, but **which** women

Who is missing from parliament? (Oct. 2024 data)



Intersectionality at work

Each bar is one structure. Intersectionality asks: who sits where they cross?

Not only women: no MP is a manual worker. These are mostly men's jobs, so class shuts out many men too.

Austria doesn't track data on migrant women vs. migrant men MPs. What isn't counted isn't seen.

Sources: Austrian Parliament (women, Sept 2026); Der Standard count, Oct 2024 (at least 12 MPs with a known migration background); Statistik Austria (population 2025); Momentum Institut 2025 (age, education, occupation; occupations as share of employed people); Robert Bosch Stiftung 2025 (Germany).

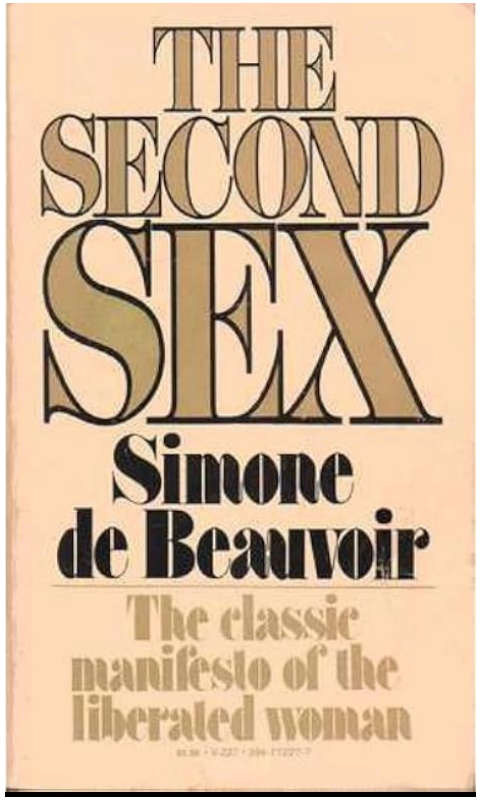
IV. Rethinking the very categories of male/female

Gender as a social and political construction

Simone de Beauvoir: *The Second Sex* (1949)

Pathbreaking French feminist philosopher:





Simone de Beauvoir: *The Second Sex* (1949)

Famously argued: "One is not born, but rather becomes, a woman"

- Being "woman" or "man" is not a stable state.
- It is an ongoing accomplishment, something that **is actively done *to* individuals, and *by* individuals unto themselves.**
- Women, and men, over thousands of years have been "pressed" into falsely stable categories of "woman" versus "man"
- This has forced women, like men too, to live "inauthentic" lives
- Denying that even over our own life-course, our bodies change dramatically. From baby, to puberty, to reproductive years, to old age, our bodies are very unstable.
- Yet, **we deny this flexibility and change, forcing a static and oppressive notion of the stable body**, as if it has one meaning as "man" and "woman"

Judith Butler's *Gender Trouble* (1990)

- Heavily influenced by Beauvoir
- American philosopher: Argues that there is NO 'real' basis to gender
- Gender is a radically socially constructed **performance**



Gender versus Sex: Judith Butler's *Gender Trouble* (1990)

- Questioned the line between **"sex"** (biology) and **"gender"** (culture): for Butler, even how we understand "sex" is shaped by gender norms
- Gender as a **performance**:

> ***"Gender reality is performative which means, quite simply, that it is real only to the extent that it is performed"***

- A radically social-constructionist view, more so than Beauvoir

Butler: sex does not determine gender

Common assumption
each one follows from the one before

Sex
the body: female / male → **Gender**
feminine / masculine → **Desire**
attracted to the “opposite” sex

“A female body makes you feminine, and makes you desire men.” Butler calls this the **heterosexual matrix**.

Butler
no chain: gender norms shape all three

Gender norms, repeated again and again: clothes, voice, gestures

Sex
how we classify bodies

×

Gender
feminine, masculine, both, neither

×

Desire
not fixed by sex or gender

Gender is something we **do**, again and again, not something that follows from the body. Even “sex” is read through gender norms.

Butler: Drag is serious business



> *"In imitating gender, drag implicitly reveals the imitative structure of gender itself – as well as its contingency."*
>
> Butler, Gender Trouble (1990)

Butler: We cannot presume any necessary link between:

Sex	×	**Gender**	×	**Desire**
the given body		masculine / feminine		whom the person desires

Why this is political: drag shows that the "natural" chain from body to gender to desire is not natural at all. It is a copy with no original.

Once we see that, the norms that rank some bodies, genders and desires as "normal" and others as deviant can be **questioned and changed**.

From institutions to gender itself as political



LENSES 1–3

Gender in politics

Focus: formal institutions: parliament, laws, pay, quotas

Question: are women included, and which women?

"Woman" is taken as a given.

LENS 4

The politics of gender

Focus: gender norms themselves: bodies, identities, everyday life

Question: who decides what counts as a "woman" or a "man"?

"Woman" becomes the question.

Today, gender itself is a political battlefield:

Should there be a third gender entry? (Austria: "divers", since a 2018 court ruling)

Drag shows and Pride events: celebrated, or banned?

Campaigns against "gender ideology"

In sum: four lenses we examined today

	Lens	The problem is…	Change means…	On quotas
Gender in politics formal institutions	**Liberal**	Barriers that block individual women	Equal rights and laws, within the system	Split: removes a barrier vs. overrides merit
	Marxist	Capitalism + patriarchy; unpaid work	Transforming work, wages and care	Good, but not enough: class stays the same
	Intersectional	"Women" and "men" treated as one group	Centring the most marginalized as leaders	Which women (and men) get the seats?
The politics of gender gender itself	**Gender as a construct**	Norms that make gender look natural	Questioning the categories themselves	*A different question: who decides what a "woman" or "man" is?*

Not a complete list, but it shows the richness of feminism and its internal tensions.